

Shield Variants

This rule modifies the standard shield rules to add additional types of shields. In standard 5th edition D&D, there is only one kind of shield (outside of magic items). By adding additional shields as mundane equipment, it opens additional considerations and strategies for characters when deciding whether or not they should use a shield. The following variants of shields are added as mundane equipment, and standard magical variants (+1, +2, +3) are added for those that do not have them already.

Light shields. Light shields, sometimes known as bucklers, are smaller shields intended be used alongside larger weapons or wielded as a lightweight alternative to larger shields. Proficiency with a light shield can be gained automatically by having proficiency with both light armor and either martial weapons or standard (medium) shields; if you have proficiency with heavy shields, you automatically gain proficiency with light shields as well. Bucklers cost 6 gp and weigh 3 lbs.

Functionally, they differ from medium shields in the following ways: 1. The AC benefit is +1 instead of the +2 that is standard for bigger shields. 2. The buckler is strapped to the arm instead of held in hand, allowing the wielder a free hand; however, if you use your buckler hand in order to make a melee attack with a weapon that has the *heavy* property, you lose the benefits of your buckler until the start of your next turn.

Medium Shields. Medium shields are the standard shield currently in D&D. Whenever a feature mentions a shield without a type (like in the Shield Master feat), it can be assumed to be referring to medium shields; at the DM's discretion, the effects of those features can be extended and potentially modified to apply to heavy and light shields. Proficiency with both medium armor and martial weapons automatically grants proficiency with medium shields; gaining any shield proficiency also grants medium shield proficiency as well.

Heavy Shields. Heavy shields typically refer to tower shields; these are massive shields that provide substantially more cover than smaller, lighter variants. You can gain proficiency with heavy shields by having proficiency with both heavy armor and either martial weapons or standard (medium) shields; gaining proficiency with heavy shields automatically grants proficiency with light and medium shields. Tower shields (the standard heavy shield) cost 20 gp and weigh 12 lbs.

Functionally, they differ from medium shields in the following ways: 1. Heavy shields grant the user the ability to brace themselves behind their shield. As a bonus action, or in place of an attack when they take the Attack Action, the wielder can gain the benefits of half-cover; this benefit lasts until the beginning of your next turn, and while it is active, your movement speed is halved. You can choose to end this benefit early, no action required. 2. If your Strength score is not at least 13, all your movement speeds are decreased by 5 feet.